Tain't So

By Langston Hughes

LANGSTON: **(Pg 209-212)** Miss Lucy Cannon was a right nice old white woman, except that she really did ***not*** like colored folks, not even after she come out West to California. She could never get over certain little Southern ways she had, and long as she knowed my Uncle Joe, she never would call him ***Mister*** -- nor any other colored man for that matter, not even the minister of the Baptist Church. Miss Lucy Cannon just wouldn't call colored folks ***Mister*** nor ***Missus***, no matter who they was.

She was always ailing around, too, and ever so often she would have a fainting spell, like all good Southern white ladies. Looks like the older she got, the more she would be sick and couldn't hardly get around -- that is, until she went to a healer and got cured.

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And that is one of the funniest stories Uncle Joe ever told me, how old Miss Cannon got cured of her heart and hip in just one cure at the healer's.

INTRODUCTION

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LANGSTON: Seems like for three years or more she could scarcely walk -- even with a cane -- had a terrible bad pain in her right leg from her knee up. And on her left side, her heart was always just about to give out. She was in bad shape, that old Southern lady, to be as spry as she was, always giving teas and dinners and working her colored help to death.

Well, Uncle Joe says, one New Year's Day a friend of hers, a Northern lady who was kinda old and retired also told Miss Cannon . . .

NORTHERN LADY: Darling, you seem to suffer so all the time, and you say you've tried all the doctors, and all kinds of baths and medicines. Why don't you try my way of overcoming? Why don't you try faith?

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MISS LUCY: *(sipping tea)* Faith, honey?

NORTHERN LADY: Yes, my dear, faith! I have one of the best faith-healers in the world. She's a woman, and she heals by power. She lives in Hollywood.

MISS LUCY: Give me her address, and I'll go to see her. How much do her treatments cost?

LANGSTON: Miss Lucy warn't so rich as some folks thought she was.

NORTHERN LADY: Only Ten Dollars, dearest. Ten Dollars a treatment. Go, and you'll come away cured.

LANGSTON: And before she could learn any more about the healer, some other friends came in and interrupted the conversation.

A few days later, however, Miss Lucy took herself all the way from Pasadena to Hollywood, and thought she would go to see the healer, which she did, come Monday morning early. Using her cane and hobbling on her left leg, feeling a bit bad around the heart, and suffering terribly in her mind, she managed to

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walk slowly but with dignity a half-dozen blocks to the rather humble street to the office and home of the healer.

When she got to the house she was seeking, a large frame dwelling, newly painted, she saw a sign thereon: **MISS PAULINE JONES**

"So that's her name," thought Miss Lucy. "Pauline Jones, Miss Jones."

Ring And Enter said a little card above the bell. So Miss Lucy entered. But the first thing that set her back a bit was that nobody received her, so she just sat down to await Miss Jones, the healer who had, she heard, an enormous following in Hollywood. In fact, that's why she had come early, so she wouldn't have to wait long. Now, it was only nine o'clock. The office was open -- but empty. So Miss Lucy simply waited. Ten minutes passed. Fifteen. Twenty. Finally she became all nervous and fluttery. Heart and limb! Pain, pain, pain! Not even a magazine to read.

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MISS LUCY: *(impatiently)* Oh, me! What is this? *(peering at a sign on the wall)* Why, I never!

LANGSTON: There was a sign on the wall that read:

BELIEVE

MISS LUCY: *(looking at her watch)* I will wait just ten minutes more.

LANGSTON: But before the ten minutes were up, another woman entered the front door and sat down. To Miss Lucy's horror, she was a colored woman! In fact, a big black colored woman!

Said Miss Lucy to herself . . .

MISS LUCY: *(softly)* I'll never in the world get used to the North. Now here's a great -- my friend says -- great faith-healer, treating darkies! Why, down in Alabama, a Negro patient wouldn't dare come in here and sit down with white people like this!

LANGSTON: But, womanlike, (and having still five minutes to wait) Miss Lucy couldn't keep her mouth shut that long. She just had to talk, albeit to a Negro, so she began on her favorite subject -- herself.

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MISS LUCY: I certainly feel bad this morning.

NEGRO WOMAN: *(placidly)* Tain't so.

LANGSTON: Which sort of took Miss Lucy back a bit.

MISS LUCY: *(lifting her chin indignantly)* Indeed, it is so! My heart is just about to give out. My breath is short.

NEGRO WOMAN: *(calmly)* Tain't so a-tall.

MISS LUCY: *(gasping)* Why! Such impudence! I tell you it is so! I could hardly get down here this morning.

NEGRO WOMAN: *(calmly)* Tain't so.

MISS LUCY: Besides my heart, my right hip pains me so I can hardly sit here.

NEGRO WOMAN: I say, tain't so.

MISS LUCY: *(screaming)* I tell you it is so! Where is the healer? I won't sit here and suffer this -- this impudence. I can't! It'll kill me! It's outrageous!

NEGRO WOMAN: *(serenely)* Tain't so.

LANGSTON: Whereupon Miss Lucy rose. Her pale face flushed a violent red.

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MISS LUCY: *(looking around the room)* Where is the healer?

NEGRO WOMAN: Right here.

MISS LUCY: What? You're the – why -- you?

NEGRO WOMAN: I'm Miss Jones.

MISS LUCY: Why, I never heard the like. A colored woman as famous as you? Why, you must be lying!

MISS JONES: *(calmly)* Tain't so.

MISS LUCY: Well, I shan't stay another minute!

MISS JONES: Ten Dollars, then. You've had your treatment, anyhow.

MISS LUCY: Ten Dollars! That's entirely too much!

MISS JONES: Tain't so.

LANGSTON: Angrily Miss Lucy opened her pocketbook, threw a Ten Dollar bill on the table, took a deep breath, and bounced out. She went three blocks up Sunset Boulevard walking like the wind, conversing with herself.

MISS LUCY: *(angrily)* Tain't so! 'Tain't so! I tell her I'm sick and she says, 'Tain't so!'

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LANGSTON: On she went at a rapid gait, stepping like a young girl -- so mad she had forgotten all about her infirmities, even her heart -- when suddenly she cried . . .

MISS LUCY: Lord, have mercy, my cane! For the first time in three years, I'm without a cane!

LANGSTON: Then she realized that her breath was giving her no trouble at all. Neither was her leg. Her temper mellowed. The sunshine was sweet and warm. She felt good.

MISS LUCY: *(smiling to herself)* Colored folks do have some funny kind of supernatural conjuring powers, I reckon. *(her face going grim again)* But the impudence of 'em! Soon's they get up North -- calling herself Miss Pauline Jones. The idea! Putting on airs and charging me Ten Dollars for a handful of Tain't so's!

LANGSTON: In her mind she clearly heard . . .

MISS JONES: Tain't so!

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